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Defense Acquisitions Academy

CONTRACTOR EDITION

The Contractor's Acquisition Starter Kit

A practical field guide for defense contractors, BD professionals, and proposal teams navigating the U.S. Government acquisition landscape.

Built by the experts at Acqlerate

Last Updated: July 2026

Reflects FAC 2025-07

What's Updated in This Edition

- SAT (Simplified Acquisition Threshold) raised to $350,000 (was $250,000) — FAC 2025-07
- MPT (Micro-Purchase Threshold) raised to $15,000 (was $10,000) — FAC 2025-07
- TINA threshold raised to $10M for certified cost or pricing data — FY2026 NDAA (was $2.5M)
- EVMS thresholds raised to $50M (non-validated) / $100M (validated required) — DFARS Class Deviation 2026-O0011 (was $20M / $50M)
- CMMC Phase 2 SUSPENDED (Jul 13, 2026) — third-party C3PAO certification paused indefinitely pending a 60-day CMMC Reform Task Force review; Phase 1 self-assessments still required, DFARS 7012 & NIST 800-171 still fully enforced
- The Revolutionary FAR Overhaul (RFO) is rewriting most of the FAR in 2026 under EO 14275 — still called the FAR, agencies are adopting rewritten parts via interim class deviations before formal rulemaking finishes; verify which parts your buying office has adopted
- DUNS replaced by UEI (Unique Entity Identifier) — SAM.gov registration updated
- OTA (Other Transaction Authority): $23B+ awarded in FY2025, up from $3.4B in FY2017
- Footer updated: reflects FAC 2025-07 & the RFO, July 2026

The Contractor's Acquisition Starter Kit

Whether you're building your first pipeline or optimizing a mature capture strategy, understanding how the government buys is the foundation of sustainable contract growth. This kit covers the five essential knowledge areas every contractor must master: contract vehicle types, IDIQ and A&AS; structures, who's actually buying, the vocabulary of acquisition, and the costly mistakes that derail even experienced firms. Use this as your go-to reference — and share it with your BD, capture, and contracts teams.

IDIQs, Fair Opportunity, and Contract Structures

Understanding the difference between task orders and standalone contracts is foundational for any defense contractor. A standalone contract is a direct award for a specific, defined requirement — it has its own solicitation, proposal, evaluation, and award process. A task order, by contrast, is issued under a pre-existing Indefinite Delivery Indefinite Quantity (IDIQ) vehicle. The IDIQ itself is the umbrella agreement; task orders are the individual delivery mechanisms under it. Winning a place on an IDIQ vehicle does not guarantee revenue — it guarantees the right to compete for task orders.

An IDIQ contract establishes a ceiling value and a minimum guarantee (often nominal) with one or more contractors. The government retains flexibility to order services or supplies over the life of the contract — typically 5 years with options — without re-competing every requirement from scratch. This structure dramatically reduces procurement lead time and gives the government agility in a fast-moving environment.

Feature	Single Award IDIQ	Multiple Award IDIQ (MA-IDIQ)
Award Structure	One contractor holds the vehicle. All task orders go to that firm without further competition.	Multiple contractors hold the vehicle. Task orders competed among awardees under fair opportunity (FAR 16.505).
Revenue Certainty	High — maximum certainty per win. Harder to win at award.	Shared pool — must compete for each task order. Requires sustained BD effort post-award.
Entry Difficulty	Very High — requires strong technical differentiation	Moderate — easier vehicle entry, harder revenue certainty
Common Use	Highly specialized or single-qualified-source requirements	Dominant IDIQ model in defense contracting — broad services/IT
Competition Post-Award	Low — less competition, high incumbent advantage on recompete	High — fair opportunity exceptions are narrow and scrutinized (FAR 16.505(b)(2))

Fair Opportunity Exceptions (FAR 16.505(b)(2))

While fair opportunity is the rule, the government may bypass it in specific circumstances: when the need is unusually urgent, when only one awardee is capable, when a sole-source order is in the public interest, when the order must follow an order-specific competition, or when a logical follow-on applies. Contractors should understand these exceptions because they represent both a risk (competitor receives a sole-source order you should have competed for) and an opportunity (your firm may qualify for an exception in the right circumstances).

Feature	Standalone Contract	Single Award IDIQ	Multiple Award IDIQ
Competition Level	Full & Open or Set-Aside	Single competition at award	Competition at vehicle + task order
Revenue Certainty	High (if awarded)	Very High	Moderate — depends on win rate

Feature	Standalone Contract	Single Award IDIQ	Multiple Award IDIQ
Entry Difficulty	Moderate to High	Very High	Moderate
Typical Duration	1–5 years	5–10 years	5–10 years
BD Effort Post-Award	Low	Low	High — continuous
Common Use Cases	Unique, defined scope	Specialized capability	Broad services / IT requirements

The Procurement Office Behind Major DoD Acquisitions

GSA Assisted Acquisition Services - Defense (AAS-D) is not a contract vehicle. It is a procurement office within GSA's Federal Acquisition Service (FAS), operated through FEDSIM, with roughly 300 employees supporting defense acquisitions. AAS-D is organized around five defense-focused components: Army, Air Force, DoD, Geographic Combatant Commands, and Navy.

For contractors, AAS-D matters because it is often the acquisition engine behind large, complex DoD requirements. Understanding how it works helps you identify where opportunities originate, how requirements are shaped, and why some of the biggest defense buys are executed through GSA rather than directly by the customer agency.

What AAS-D Is	Why It Exists
A specialized acquisition office inside GSA FAS that supports DoD missions through FEDSIM-managed procurements. Provides the contracting infrastructure, process discipline, and source selection execution for complex buys. • Not a contract vehicle • Operates through FEDSIM • Focused on defense requirements • Supports major interagency acquisitions	AAS-D fills acquisition capacity gaps when DoD organizations need speed, expertise, and scale. Designed for requirements too large, complex, or specialized for routine local contracting offices. • Reduces acquisition workload on DoD teams • Accelerates award timelines • Brings deep federal procurement expertise • Supports highly visible, protest-sensitive buys

Why DoD Agencies Use AAS-D

DoD customers turn to AAS-D when they need acquisition expertise they do not have in-house, when they need to move faster than their internal process allows, or when the requirement is too complex to manage locally. AAS-D is also attractive because it has a 99% win rate on protest challenges, which makes it a strong choice for defensible, documentation-heavy source selections.

Capability Gap	Speed	Complexity	Protest Strength
Used when program offices lack the contracting depth or source-selection bandwidth to manage a major acquisition internally.	FEDSIM's centralized model can reduce friction and move complex requirements forward faster than a traditional decentralized process.	Best suited for large, multi-stakeholder efforts requiring rigorous documentation, evaluation structure, and protest resilience.	AAS-D's highly disciplined approach contributes to an exceptionally strong protest record — 99% win rate.

What AAS-D Buys for DoD

The portfolio is dominated by a handful of service categories. Contractors should recognize where their capabilities fit and how contract type expectations may shape pricing and proposal strategy.

Program Mgmt & Acquisition Support	IT & Telecommunications	Special Studies & Analysis	Computer System Design & Development
Planning, oversight, governance, and acquisition execution for major defense programs.	Networks, platforms, communications infrastructure, and enterprise IT services.	Independent assessments, analytical support, market research, and decision support work.	Software, systems engineering, integration, and development of mission systems.

Professional Engineering Services: Technical engineering support across acquisition, design, test, and sustainment activities.

Contract type mix: AAS-D awards are commonly structured as FFP (~40%) and CPAF (~24%), so contractors should be prepared for both fixed-price execution and cost-plus performance risk allocation.

Key DoD Customers

These are some of the most important DoD organizations using AAS-D. ASTRO is a flagship MA-IDIQ vehicle frequently associated with platform support services and major federal mission support work.

Customer	Program / Vehicle	Notable Value
Dept. of the Air Force	DC3	$347M
U.S. Army USACE	RITS	$1.3B
Defense Threat Reduction Agency	JIDO	$326M
SOCOM	Special operations requirements	Major recurring customer
Navy	Mission support and technical services	Major recurring customer

What Contractors Need to Know

Search the Right Place: Watch SAM.gov, not agency-specific portals. Search for 'Federal Systems Integration and Management Center' to find relevant AAS-D opportunities.

Expect Rigor: Source selections are documentation-heavy and highly structured. Proposals must be clear, traceable, and defensible.

Don't Assume Incumbency Helps: Incumbents do not automatically retain an advantage. AAS-D competitions are designed to test current value and execution risk.

Understand the Interagency Dynamic: GSA contracting officers execute the procurement, while the DoD program office owns the requirement and technical evaluation inputs.

Pro Tip: ASTRO and Platform Support Positioning

Build a weekly routine around SAM.gov searches for Federal Systems Integration and Management Center, then monitor FEDSIM/AAS-D opportunities consistently. The best teams review the pipeline every week so they can shape capture early, not after the solicitation drops.

Navigating the Air Force Contracting Enterprise — AFICC/ESS, Base-Level, and MAJCOM Contracting

One of the most underestimated competitive advantages a defense contractor can develop is a precise understanding of who actually issues the contract. The Air Force contracting enterprise is not monolithic — it is divided into distinct organizational layers, each with different authorities, contract size thresholds, mission focus, and levels of accessibility to industry. Confusing these layers leads to misaligned BD strategy, wasted proposal resources, and missed opportunities.

AFICC / Enterprise Sourcing Squadrons (ESS)	Base-Level Contracting Squadrons	MAJCOM / Service Component Command
Air Force Installation and Mission Support Center's contracting arm. ESS units handle large-dollar, enterprise-level acquisitions across installations and functional areas. Think sustainment, services, IT infrastructure.	Installation-specific contracting offices handling day-to-day requirements under simplified acquisition thresholds and mid-tier contracts. High transaction volume, lower average contract value. Strong relationship opportunity for small businesses.	Commands like USAFE-AFAFRICA, ACC, AMC, and AFSOC have contracting support aligned to their mission. Acquisitions are operationally sensitive, higher classification, and tied to theater or combat support requirements.

The Air Force Installation Contracting Center (AFICC) and its Enterprise Sourcing Squadrons represent the most accessible entry point for mid-size to large contractors seeking multi-year service contracts. ESS offices typically manage requirements from $1M to well over $100M, running formal source selections with written proposals, oral presentations, and structured evaluation criteria. These competitions reward thorough market research, strong PWS/SOW alignment, and credible past performance.

Base-level contracting squadrons are where relationships matter most. These offices process thousands of smaller actions annually — blanket purchase agreements, simplified acquisitions, and sole-source justifications under SAP thresholds. For small businesses and new market entrants, base-level contracting provides the fastest pathway to building past performance. Contracting Officers at the base level value reliable incumbents highly, making early market entry and COR relationship-building critical.

MAJCOM-aligned contracting, such as the contracting operations supporting USAFE-AFAFRICA or Air Combat Command, handles operationally-driven requirements that often carry unique classification, OCONUS, or mission-specific constraints. These opportunities are less visible on SAM.gov and often require security clearances, theater knowledge, and existing relationships with program offices. Entry is harder but competition is typically less crowded.

Dimension	AFICC / ESS	Base-Level Contracting	MAJCOM / Component
Typical Contract Size	$1M–$100M+	Under $1M (SAP range)	$500K–$50M+ (varies)
Competition Type	Formal source selection	Simplified, BPA, sole-source	Formal to streamlined
Entry Difficulty	Moderate–High	Low–Moderate	High (clearance, access)
Visibility (SAM.gov)	High	Moderate	Low–Moderate

Dimension	AFICC / ESS	Base-Level Contracting	MAJCOM / Component
Relationship Weight	Moderate	Very High	High
Best For	Mid/large contractors	Small business, new entrants	Cleared, mission-specialized firms

70+ Essential Acquisition Terms — Organized by Category

The U.S. defense acquisition ecosystem runs on acronyms. Fluency in this vocabulary is not optional — it is a professional baseline. From proposal writing to contract performance, the ability to interpret and use these terms accurately signals credibility to government customers and sets professional standards within your own team. This glossary is organized by category for rapid reference. Use it to onboard new staff, prep for source selection, or refresh before a government meeting.

Contract Types

Term	Definition
FFP	Firm Fixed Price — contractor bears all cost risk
T&M;	Time and Materials — hourly rate + materials, cost risk shared
CPFF	Cost Plus Fixed Fee — gov't pays costs + fixed fee
CPIF	Cost Plus Incentive Fee — incentive for under-budget delivery
CPAF	Cost Plus Award Fee — fee based on periodic performance evaluation
IDIQ	Indefinite Delivery Indefinite Quantity — flexible ordering vehicle
IDC	Indefinite Delivery Contract — umbrella for IDIQ, BOA, BPA
BPA	Blanket Purchase Agreement — simplified repetitive purchasing
OTA	Other Transaction Agreement — non-FAR vehicle for R&D; and prototyping ($23B+ in FY2025)
MAC	Multiple Award Contract — IDIQ with multiple awardees
TO	Task Order — delivery mechanism under IDIQ/MAC
DO	Delivery Order — for supplies under IDIQ
BOA	Basic Ordering Agreement — framework for future orders
BVTO	Best Value Tradeoff — evaluation weighing quality vs. price
LPTA	Lowest Price Technically Acceptable — price-dominant evaluation
SAP	Simplified Acquisition Procedures — streamlined for smaller buys
SAT	Simplified Acquisition Threshold — $350,000 (FAC 2025-07)
MPT	Micro-Purchase Threshold — $15,000 (FAC 2025-07)

Term	Definition
FAR	Federal Acquisition Regulation — primary procurement rulebook
DFARS	Defense FAR Supplement — DoD-specific FAR additions
RFP	Request for Proposal — formal solicitation for competitive bids
RFQ	Request for Quotation — price-focused, for simplified acquisitions
RFI	Request for Information — market research, not a solicitation
SOO	Statement of Objectives — outcome-based requirement descriptor
SOW	Statement of Work — prescriptive, task-level work description
PWS	Performance Work Statement — outcome-based work description
QASP	Quality Assurance Surveillance Plan — how gov't measures performance
SSP	Source Selection Plan — documents evaluation criteria and process
SSEB	Source Selection Evaluation Board — evaluates proposals
SSA	Source Selection Authority — final award decision maker
TINA	Truth in Negotiations Act — requires certified pricing data above $10M (FY2026 NDAA)
CMMC	Cybersecurity Maturity Model Certification — Phase 2 suspended Jul 2026; Phase 1 self-assessments still required
RFO	Revolutionary FAR Overhaul — the 2026 rewrite of the FAR under EO 14275, still called the FAR

Roles & Personnel

Term	Definition
CO	Contracting Officer — legal authority to award and administer contracts
KO	Kontract Officer — alternate abbreviation for CO
COR	Contracting Officer's Representative — technical oversight during performance
ACOR	Alternate COR — backup to the COR
PCO	Procuring Contracting Officer — handles award
ACO	Administrative Contracting Officer — handles post-award administration
TCO	Terminating Contracting Officer — manages contract termination
PM	Program/Project Manager — leads program/project execution
PO	Program Office — government team responsible for a program
BD	Business Development — identifies and pursues contract opportunities
CP	Capture Manager — leads competitive strategy for a specific opportunity
TPOC	Technical Point of Contact — government technical subject matter expert

Term	Definition
CPARS	Contractor Performance Assessment Reporting System — official ratings
PPIRS	Past Performance Info Retrieval System — database of CPARS records
DCAA	Defense Contract Audit Agency — audits contractor financials
DCMA	Defense Contract Management Agency — admin/oversight post-award
CDRL	Contract Data Requirements List — list of required deliverables
DID	Data Item Description — format/content spec for a CDRL
EAC	Estimate at Completion — projected final program cost
ETC	Estimate to Complete — remaining work cost projection
BAC	Budget at Completion — total authorized budget
SPI	Schedule Performance Index — EVM schedule efficiency metric
CPI	Cost Performance Index — EVM cost efficiency metric
EVMS	Earned Value Management System — $50M non-validated; $100M validated
POP	Period of Performance — contract duration

Organizations & Programs

Term	Definition
DoD	Department of Defense
DAF	Department of the Air Force
USAF	United States Air Force
USSF	United States Space Force
AFICC	AF Installation & Mission Support Center Contracting
ESS	Enterprise Sourcing Squadron
AFMC	Air Force Materiel Command
USAFE	US Air Forces in Europe
ACC	Air Combat Command
AMC	Air Mobility Command
MAJCOM	Major Command
PEO	Program Executive Office
SAF	Secretary of the Air Force
GSA	General Services Administration
SBA	Small Business Administration

Term	Definition
SB	Small Business
SDVOSB	Service-Disabled Veteran-Owned Small Business
VOSB	Veteran-Owned Small Business
WOSB	Women-Owned Small Business
HUBZone	Historically Underutilized Business Zone
8(a)	SBA 8(a) Business Development Program
SDB	Small Disadvantaged Business
NAICS	North American Industry Classification System
PSC	Product Service Code
CAGE	Commercial and Government Entity Code
UEI	Unique Entity Identifier (SAM.gov) — replaced DUNS
OSDBU	Office of Small and Disadvantaged Business Utilization
FEDSIM	Federal Systems Integration and Management Center (GSA)
AAS-D	Assisted Acquisition Services - Defense (GSA)
OASIS+	One Acquisition Solution for Integrated Services Plus (GSA GWAC)

Pro Tip: Terminology Signals Credibility

Government evaluators and contracting officers will form immediate impressions of your team's professionalism based on how accurately you use acquisition terminology in proposals, white papers, and meetings. Misusing terms like SOW vs. PWS or CO vs. COR signals inexperience and can undermine an otherwise strong technical proposal. Note: UEI (Unique Entity Identifier) has fully replaced DUNS for SAM.gov registration.

Avoid These Pitfalls Before They Cost You the Contract

Even experienced defense contractors leave significant revenue on the table by repeating the same acquisition errors year after year. These are not obscure edge cases — they are systematic gaps in pipeline strategy, relationship management, and compliance posture that show up across firms of all sizes. Recognizing these patterns is the first step to eliminating them from your capture and delivery operations.

1

No Pipeline Strategy — Chasing vs. Planning

The most common and costly mistake: treating BD as reactive rather than strategic. Contractors who chase every opportunity on SAM.gov without a disciplined pipeline framework waste proposal resources, burn out their teams, and win at low rates. A mature pipeline strategy identifies target customers 12–18 months before RFP release, maps vehicle opportunities aligned to your NAICS codes and capabilities, and scores opportunities by pWin (probability of win) before committing proposal resources. Without this, you are funding your competitor's market research.

2

Ignoring the COR — Focusing Only on the CO

The Contracting Officer's Representative is the government's day-to-day technical interface during contract performance — and one of the most influential voices in CPARS ratings and recompete positioning. Contractors who treat the COR as an administrative checkpoint rather than a strategic relationship miss the single best source of performance feedback, requirement shaping intelligence, and past performance narrative. Build a structured engagement plan with the COR from contract kickoff. Deliver proactive status updates, document issues in writing, and ensure your PM treats every COR interaction as a performance evaluation in progress.

3

Confusing PWS and SOW — Proposing the Wrong Way

A Statement of Work (SOW) tells you what to do in prescriptive, task-level detail. A Performance Work Statement (PWS) tells you what outcome to achieve, leaving the method to the contractor. These are not interchangeable — and responding to a PWS with an SOW-style proposal (listing activities instead of outcomes) is a red flag to evaluators. Always read the solicitation's work description type carefully and tailor your technical approach accordingly. PWS-based proposals should describe your management framework, metrics, and outcomes — not a labor hour breakdown by task.

4

DCAA Compliance Gaps — Discovered at the Worst Time

The Defense Contract Audit Agency conducts pre-award surveys, incurred cost audits, and forward pricing reviews that can kill a contract award or trigger costly remediation during performance. Contractors — especially those transitioning from commercial work to cost-reimbursable contracts — frequently discover DCAA compliance gaps only after award, when the pressure is highest. Common gaps include inadequate timekeeping systems, unallowable cost pooling, missing written policies for compensation and travel, and indirect rate structures that don't align to contract requirements. Establish a compliant accounting system before pursuing cost-type work, not after. Engage a DCAA-savvy CPA or contracts attorney early. Note: For cost-type contracts, be aware of the TINA threshold ($10M, raised under the FY2026 NDAA) and EVMS requirements ($50M non-validated; $100M validated).

5

No Recompete Plan — Losing What You Already Won

Contractors routinely focus 90% of their capture energy on new business while neglecting the most winnable opportunity in their portfolio: the contract they already hold. Recompete planning should begin at contract award — not 12 months before expiration. A recompete plan documents performance wins, maintains CPARS narrative alignment, tracks staffing continuity risks, monitors competitive intelligence on challenger firms, and coordinates capture strategy with delivery teams in real time. The incumbent win rate on federal contracts is not as high as most contractors assume — and a poorly executed recompete can erase years of revenue in a single award decision.

CMMC Update (Cybersecurity Maturity Model Certification): Phase 1 (self-assessment) has been in effect since November 10, 2025 and remains required. Phase 2 — the mandatory third-party (C3PAO) certification originally set for November 10, 2026 — was suspended by DoD on July 13, 2026 pending a 60-day review by a new CMMC Reform Task Force. That does not mean cybersecurity compliance went away: DFARS 252.204-7012 and NIST SP 800-171 are still fully enforced through self-assessments and select government-led assessments, and your SPRS score still drives source selection. Contractors handling Controlled Unclassified Information (CUI) should keep their self-assessment current and watch for the task force's findings — C3PAO requirements could return in a revised form.

Other Transaction Authority (OTA) — Growing Fast: The DoD obligated $23B+ in OTA awards in FY2025, up from just $3.4B in FY2017 — a nearly 7x increase in eight years. OTAs operate outside FAR/DFARS requirements, making them faster and more flexible for prototype and follow-on production. Contractors not tracking OTA consortia (like NSTXL, AFWERX, and DIU vehicles) are missing a major and growing segment of defense spending.

Defense Acquisitions Academy — Built for Contractors Like You

This Starter Kit is your foundation — but winning in the defense contracting space requires continuous learning, updated market intelligence, and mastery of the full acquisition lifecycle. Acqlerate has built the industry's most contractor-focused acquisition training curriculum, designed specifically for BD professionals, capture managers, proposal leads, and contract administrators supporting the U.S. Government.

Module 1: DoD Acquisitions Foundations Acquisition lifecycle, ACAT levels, key roles (PM, CO, COR, DCMA), OTAs, and FAR Part 12 — the essential foundation for every BD and contracts professional.	**Module 2: Defense Contracting Fundamentals** Contract types, the full contract lifecycle, solicitation, source selection, administration, modifications, and REAs — how DoD actually buys.
Module 3: Capture Management & BD Solicitation development, evaluation criteria, proposal compliance, and source selection from the buyer's side — write to what the government actually scores.	**Module 4: Defense Finance & Budgeting** PPBE, appropriations law, EVM, cost estimating, and DCAA oversight — the money side every contractor needs to speak fluently.
Module 5: Data Analytics for Program Managers Program metrics and KPIs, the EVM acronym deep dive, and reading IPMR reports — the numbers your government customer is already looking at.	**Module 6: PM Operations & Leadership** Risk management, stakeholder communication, and program reviews — how the government side runs a program, so you can work with it instead of against it.

Why Acqlerate?	Start Learning Today
• Built by acquisition practitioners — not academics • Contractor-focused curriculum (not just government PMs) • Aligned to current FAR/DFARS and DoDI policy • Air Force, Space Force, and DoD-relevant content • Self-paced modules with practical tools and templates • Credentialing recognized by acquisition professionals	Join hundreds of defense contractors accelerating their acquisition expertise with Acqlerate's structured, practitioner-led curriculum. Learn at your own pace, earn credentials your customers recognize, and build the institutional knowledge that separates winning firms from the rest. Explore All 6 Modules at acqlerate.com

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